

Emerging Leaders Program Application

Statement

Since joining the public service, I've come to appreciate that this work can change people's lives. From an economics background, the analysis we do and the excel calculations done can potentially translate to policies that really have meaningful impact on the people of Tonga. With that sense of purpose, I am inspired to apply for this ARISE 2050 program and view this platform as an invaluable opportunity to gain direct practical experience and exposure at the center of the decision-making process, and to collaborate with like-minded youth from various disciplines. It will prove a unique opportunity to be see the real issues Tonga's faces and gaining a better understanding of the strategic solutions that feed into the national development plans, and the broader regional and global development pathways over the next 20-30 years.

- **Reasons for applying for ELP:** - This program is unique to me for its (1) practical exposure and (2) investment in early career youths who can contribute to meaningful change. I am motivated to apply to:
 - Gain direct practical exposure to national frameworks that cover the key issues Tonga's facing and trace the strategy pathway in the long-term
 - Be mentored in redefining leadership skills - i.e seeing it not as a position of authority but as a style of improving decision making processes
 - Work in a multi-disciplinary team and gaining a range of perspectives on the same issue.
- **Expectations & Benefits to career aspiration** - There is always opportunity to learn and I hope to contribute/gain further understanding around these issues.
 - Further elaborating on multi-disciplinary teams. Alot of issues I run into at work require other dimensions such as understanding legal frameworks, public administration, digital innovation , journalism, environmental concerns, and others. I hope ARISE 2050 creates a space for these different perspectives to challenge each other and work together to derive effective solutions. Additionally, building relationships with the cohort is also a significant benefit of this program.
 - From economics and statistics, I value the importance of **data driven insights**. I hope a way to improve the confidence of early career professionals to engage in meetings and discussions, which i observe can feel hard to participate in due to fear of hierarchy, age, tradition or seniority- these things can be overcome if inputs and claims are approached from a factual data-driven angle. I hope to see more this culture in meeting spaces and how to nurture that from a position of leadership.
- **What have I learned from a space similar to the Pacific Island Forum meetings** - A profound message I learnt at the pacific peer-learning meeting hosted by IMF for macrodiagnostics and stories from Technical Assistance (TA), was that the institutions that flourish weren't the ones with the most advanced models or the most qualified people, but were the institutions who committed to a process that developed talent, shared knowledge, and established *continuity*. To me, this meant that good leadership was critically essential that created nurturing spaces that produced good workers.

The consistent theme across these experiences is that effective leadership is a key determinant of creating success in work and across the institution. ARISE 2050 presents an opportunity to strengthen this understanding of leadership and to learn from others

Conclusion

In summary, I see the Emerging Leaders Programme as a unique opportunity to further develop my ability to contribute to stronger public institutions in Tonga. I believe the combination of practical exposure, multidisciplinary learning, and engagement with other emerging leaders will strengthen my capacity to improve both the scope and quality of policy-making. I am committed to applying these learnings in my current and future roles within the public sector.